been the lodestars of the Tata Group.

Chandrasekaran feels that the Tata Group has certain timeless values that form the bedrock of its growth, and he is committed to upholding them in both letter and spirit. He says that his mission would be to conduct business holding sacrosanct JRD's maxim 'that no success or achievement in material terms is worthwhile, unless it serves the needs or interests of the country and its people and is achieved by fair and honest means'. In the Tata philosophy, he says, it is not only profit that matters but the guiding principle: 'What is good for India is good for the Tatas.' At the fundamental level, both Ratan and Chandrasekaran have worked to strengthen the present while preparing for the future, exhibiting long-term vision. Just as Ratan, in his early days as chairman, had worked on the Strategic Plans, emphasizing the importance of technology to strengthen group companies to face the challenges of economic liberalization, Chandrasekaran has kept his eye on the future, looking at the digital universe that holds the key to the future success of any business.

Their priorities also converge. Chandrasekaran says that his focus is to ensure 'commonness' and 'synergy' in the group and to accord high importance to 'humility', 'high integrity and values' and 'collective leadership'. These words reflect, in word and spirit, the hallmark of Ratan's leadership ethos. Speaking about the conglomerate's biggest asset, Chandrasekaran echoes what Ratan had underlined when he was restructuring the companies—the Tata 'brand' in which millions repose their trust. In an interview, he said: 'Fundamentally, we must live the brand, every single day, and we must live it better every single day.'

There are some striking similarities in their leadership styles as well. Both empower their staff. As Srinivasa Raghavan, MD, TVS Group, who had worked closely with Chandrasekaran during his stint at TCS, said in 2017, 'His [Chandrasekaran's] leadership style is to empower people. He is good at spotting leaders and then giving them space to grow, while being available for guidance.' With such commonness in approach and priorities between Ratan and Chandrasekaran and the software veteran's sterling performance at TCS, he looked like the natural choice to many observers to head Tata Sons.

After having assessed Chandrasekaran's strengths, in December 2016, Ratan called him for a meeting and dropped the hint that he could be the frontrunner to head Tata Sons. He was asked what his plans would be if he